

STUDENT-ATHLETE SUDDEN CARDIAC ARREST

This regulation sets forth the procedures to implement Policy 8440, which supports the need to inform and educate coaches, student-athletes, and student-athletes' parents or guardians about the nature and risk of sudden cardiac arrest, procedures for removal from and return to play, and the risks of not reporting symptoms.

A. Definitions

1. Automated External Defibrillator (AED). A medical device designed to analyze heart rhythm and, if appropriate, deliver an electrical shock to individuals experiencing ventricular fibrillation (a type of arrhythmia) in an effort to restore a normal heart rhythm.
2. Sudden Cardiac Arrest (SCA). A medical emergency that occurs when the heart stops beating effectively. A host of factors including electrical or structural problems in the heart can cause sudden cardiac arrest. Many of the causes of cardiac arrest are not recognized or diagnosed until the individual begins to experience adverse symptoms.
3. Cardiopulmonary Resuscitation (CPR). An emergency, life-saving procedure performed when someone's heart stops beating.
4. Commotio Cordis. A rare phenomenon in which blunt trauma to the chest causes an abnormal heart rhythm (ventricular fibrillation) that can lead to SCA.
5. Emergency Action Plan (EAP). A written document outlining emergency response procedures specific to the athletic venue.
6. Heart Attack. A medical emergency that occurs when blood flow to the heart is stopped due to a blockage in an artery supplying blood to the heart. This lack of blood flow causes heart muscle tissue to die which can lead to cardiac arrest.
7. Appropriate Licensed Health Care Provider. A physician (*i.e.*, M.D., D.O.) licensed by the Virginia Board of Medicine or a nurse practitioner licensed by the Virginia State Board of Nursing who is experienced in evaluating cardiovascular conditions.
8. Pre-Participation Physical Examination (PPE). A system-based examination designed to screen for injuries, illnesses, or other factors that may increase a student-athlete's risk for injury or illness.

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B. Sudden Cardiac Arrest in Student-Athletes1. Sudden Cardiac Arrest Team.

- a. LCPS shall form a Division-wide Sudden Cardiac Arrest Team (SCAT). The Team shall consist of at least the following individuals: two high school athletic administrators; two medically licensed athletic trainers; a lead athletic trainer; an assistant director of student activities; a high school coach; a high school parent/guardian; and a high school student-athlete.
- b. The SCAT shall meet at least once every two years, and the assistant director of student activities serving on the SCAT shall be responsible for scheduling such biennial review.
- c. The SCAT will review the training materials that LCPS's Office of Student Activities has developed for school personnel, volunteers, student-athletes, and parents/guardians of student's athletes and recommend updates thereto

2. Eligibility. In order to participate in any interscholastic athletic activity or event, each student athlete must submit results from a then-current VHSL pre-participation physical examination to the school's athletic department.

In addition, each student-athlete and the student-athlete's parent or guardian(s) shall review, on an annual basis (during each 12-month period), LCPS-provided information on sudden cardiac arrest.

After having reviewed the information about sudden cardiac arrest, each student-athlete and the student-athlete's parent or guardian shall sign a statement acknowledging receipt, review, and understanding of such information.

On an annual basis, the Superintendent or designee will determine procedures for ensuring that statements are distributed to and collected from each student-athlete their parent(s)/guardian(s) with appropriate signatures.

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3. Required Sudden Cardiac Arrest Training for School Personnel and Volunteers.

The Superintendent or designee will develop procedures to ensure school staff, coaches, assistant coaches, athletic trainers, team physicians, and volunteers or other persons serving in a coaching or advisory role over students-athletes during games and practices shall receive annual, up-to-date training, to include the following:

- a. Recognizing warning signs for sudden cardiac arrest;
- b. Practicing the school's emergency response plan for SCA; and
- c. Completing the National Federation of State High School Associations' (NFHS) Sudden Cardiac Arrest Course.

LCPS will maintain a tracking system to document compliance with the annual training requirements.

4. Removal from Activity. A student-athlete reporting any of the signs or symptoms associated with SCA to a coach, athletic trainer, or team physician in a practice or game shall be immediately removed from the activity and referred for further evaluation. A student-athlete who has been removed from play, evaluated, and suspected to be at risk of or experiencing SCA shall not return to play until they are evaluated and in receipt of written clearance to return to play by an appropriate licensed health care provider as defined by the Board of Education. Such licensed health care provider evaluating student-athletes may be a volunteer.

5. Establishment of Emergency Action Plan. Every school athletic department shall have a written emergency action plan for cardiac emergencies that is annually reviewed and practiced each sport season.

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At a minimum, each school should include the following information in its EAP:

- a. Venue Directions and Maps for All Athletic Facilities;
- b. Emergency Personnel (Emergency Response Team);
- c. Emergency Communication;
- d. Emergency Equipment;
- e. Role(s) of the First Responder;
- f. Medical Emergency Transportation; and
- g. Access to Early Defibrillation (<5 mins. from collapse to shock).

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Leg. Ref: Code of Virginia § [22.1-271.8](#), Virginia Board of Education Guidelines: Sudden cardiac arrest prevention in student-athletes.